NO. 137 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

MONDAY 19 OCTOBER 2026



THE ARC AT THREE O'CLOCK COUNTS DOWN TEN DAYS (P10)

THE WORLD

Araghchi offers seven days to reopen Hormuz; September was the strait's busiest month of the war

THE KIT

Apple's folding iPhone sold out in thirty minutes; the next ones ship around 25 January

THE ATELIER

One company owns Yale and Abloy, and they are not the same object

Twelve Desks · One World

Source: a Swiss-watch specialist title's own photograph of the Oris ProPilot Calibre 111, black dial on steel bracelet, published 16 October 2026 and opened and examined by this desk before captioning. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 137

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THE SPINE: PENCILLED IN — a reopening in seven days, a law waived before it bit, a vote about whether to vote, notices with no deadline, and a phone that arrives in January.

FROM THE DESK

"Promises and pie-crust are made to be broken."

Jonathan Swift, *Polite Conversation*, **1738**[1]

Swift put it in the mouth of a character making small talk, which is the right register for it. This issue is full of dates offered in good faith and binding on nobody: a strait that reopens on the sixth day, a referendum about holding a referendum, and a sanctions law waived the day before it was due to work.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.74%	▼ 6bp wk
US 10-year[2]	5.09%	▼ 15bp wk
VWRA	$191.68	▼ 0.94%
Global agg	$5.78	▲ 0.84%
DXY	101.84	▼ 0.36%
USD/SGD	1.2792	▼ 0.09%
Brent	$109.86	▲ 4.91%
Gold	$4,181.10	▼ 0.83%
Bitcoin	$82,156	▲ 0.58%

The Straits Times Index closed 5,415.53, up 0.25% on the week but **5.0% below its 6 October peak** (p14). Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · MONDAY

No. 130 took this desk inside locksport — the belts, the picks and the shear line. The Atelier returns to the same objects from the buying side today, and finds that the famous safe-lock maker was bought in December (p6).

No. 136 reported UKMTO could not count the attacks. This week it published a count — twenty-three this month — while the shipping trade's own ledger called September the busiest the strait has been all war (p3).

No. 115 went to Bangladesh for jhut, the garment trade's waste economy. The Long Read returns for a bigger number: a remittance record that measures something other than remittances (p21).

No. 134 printed a tanker nobody would claim. Three days on, the body that counts attacks in the Gulf has published a count — and the shipping trade's own ledger says September was the busiest the strait has been since the war began (p3).

No. 136 held a Metascore it could not read. It is 85, and it is printed today with the correction that goes with it (p11).

SOURCES 1 The line appears in Jonathan Swift's *A Complete Collection of Genteel and Ingenious Conversation*, commonly *Polite Conversation*, first published in 1738; it is spoken by a character rather than asserted by Swift, and is given here with that attribution. 2 Levels at Friday 16 October's close, each sourced on p14, with weekly changes against 9 October; Treasury yields read from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file, which this desk downloaded and re-read row by row. **The usual daily-history service reset every connection for a fourth consecutive issue.**

THE WORLD · HORMUZ

Araghchi offers to reopen Hormuz in seven days; UKMTO logs 23 attacks

Iran's foreign minister put the first number of days on the table in Baghdad on Saturday. Lloyd's List counted 477 transits in September — the strait's busiest month of the war.

Iran's foreign minister **Abbas Araghchi** told the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation's 52nd Council of Foreign Ministers in **Baghdad on Saturday 17 October** that the Strait of Hormuz could be reopened within **seven days**. The plan went to Washington through Qatar. **"The choice now rests with the United States,"** he said. A day later he set out the sequence: the strait reopens on the sixth day, talks begin on the seventh. **"Our conditions are fair."** No American official has answered on the record.[1]

That is the civilian register. The Revolutionary Guard's is unchanged: on **17 October** it said a supertanker carrying more than **two million barrels** struck a mine and exploded, and that a second tanker's engine room caught fire. No vessel name, flag or owner has been released by any party, and no maritime authority has confirmed either strike. **UKMTO** now gives a figure where last week it gave an apology: at least **ten vessels** attacked in the week to 18 October, a weekly high, and **23** since 1 October.[2]

Set against that is the shipping trade's own ledger, which describes a different sea. **Lloyd's List Intelligence** counted at least **477 transits in September** — the highest month since the war began in late February. Westbound movements into the Gulf ran **231** against 198 in August and 160 in July. Bulk carriers crossed **59** times against a March-to-May average of **24**. Its summary line is four words: *September breaks post-conflict records.* It does not use the word closed.[3]

The strait did not shut. It was priced, and the oil came out of a different door.

Both pictures are true because passage has been bought rather than stopped. Freight is now **25 to 30 per cent** of the cost of Gulf crude, against 1 to 3 before the war, and the exit has moved to India's west coast: ship-to-ship transfers in the **Gulf of Kutch** reached **82 in September**. Brent passed **$110** on Friday in New York and settled at **$109.86**.[4][5]

BAGHDAD — PRESS TV

Runs the seven-day plan as a test of American good faith and gives Araghchi the close: "*The choice now rests with the United States.*" Tehran conveyed the proposal through Qatar — the capital Singapore's prime minister reaches this week (p5).[1]

LONDON — LLOYD'S LIST INTELLIGENCE

Declines the closure frame and publishes a transit series instead. Its own summary line: "*September breaks post-conflict records.*"[3]

477

HORMUZ TRANSITS COUNTED IN SEPTEMBER, THE MOST SINCE THE WAR BEGAN IN FEBRUARY[3]

THE CHATTER · DOHA READS THE FREIGHT

Windward's **Michelle Wiese Bockmann**, to Al Jazeera: **"This is having cascading impacts for all vessel classes on freight and values across the world."** Of 45 ships Iran targeted in the third quarter, 87 per cent were tankers.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TEHRAN'S STAYING POWER

Hamidreza Azizi of the International Crisis Group puts the doubt on the other side of the ledger: **"The question, however, is whether Tehran is overestimating its ability to sustain this pressure."** The tracker still printing *Day 232 / Closed* draws it from data counting only ships that broadcast on AIS.[6]

SOURCES 1 Press TV, datelined Baghdad, 17 October 2026, read at source, for Araghchi's seven-day offer, the Qatari channel and the quoted sentence; a US network's live file of 18 October, read at source, for the sixth-day/seventh-day sequence, "Our conditions are fair", and the absence of any American response in the window. 2 Al Jazeera English and CGTN, both 18 October, read at source, for the IRGC's mine claim, the two-million-barrel figure, the second tanker and Rear Admiral Azmaei's warning. **No vessel name, flag, owner or cargo origin appears in any source this desk read, and no maritime authority has confirmed the strikes: every load-bearing detail of the 17 October attacks is an IRGC claim, printed as a claim.** UKMTO's weekly and monthly counts via the same US live file; **ukmto.org again refused this desk, so the centre's own numbers are read at one remove.** 3 Lloyd's List Intelligence, *Strait of Hormuz Brief*, 12 October 2026, read at source, for all transit series and the quoted summary line. 4 Al Jazeera, 12 October, read at source, for Windward's freight-share figures, the third-quarter targeting breakdown and both named analysts. 5 Brent and WTI levels from a US network's market file of 16 October; the Gulf of Kutch transfer figures from a maritime trade title of 16 October, **which attributes them to unnamed sources and is therefore printed as a datum, not a verified count**. 6 The open-source tracker and its own disclosure of PortWatch's AIS-only basis, its stale insurance input and its AI-assisted brief, read at source 17 October.

THE WORLD · WASHINGTON & ALBERTA

Trump waives the Graham Act's Russia sanctions a day before the tariffs bit

The order was signed on Friday 17 October; the tariffs were due on the 18th. Alberta votes today on ten questions, and its polls close at 10am Singapore time tomorrow.

President **Donald Trump** signed an order on **Friday 17 October** waiving the Russian provisions of the **Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026**, a day before they were due to bite. Waived: tariffs of up to **500 per cent** on Russian goods, up to **100 per cent** on the five largest buyers of Russian crude and gas, sanctions on foreign banks, and the bans on Russian sovereign debt and US investment there. The Act allows a waiver on certification to Congress; the White House says it filed one. The waivers run until the president or secretary of state decides otherwise, and the Act's Russian provisions sunset in **2031**.[1]

The revolt was bipartisan. **Thom Tillis**, Republican of North Carolina, called it **"beyond irresponsible"**; **John Cornyn** of Texas said Graham **"would be appalled"**. **Volodymyr Zelensky**: **"The decision to undo all of this, to block all of it, seems wrong to me."** As of Friday **no Russian diesel had been identified reaching the world market**: the thing given up is real, the thing bought for it has not arrived.[2]

> ***Alberta is not voting to leave. It is voting on whether to begin deciding whether to vote on leaving.***

Alberta votes today. Polls close at **eight in the evening Mountain Time — ten tomorrow morning in Singapore** — and the declaration is **29 October**. There are **ten questions**, not one: five on immigration and provincial services, four proposing constitutional amendments, and a tenth asking whether the government should *commence the legal process* toward a future binding referendum on separation. It is not a yes-or-no, and **none of the ten binds anyone**.[3]

SOURCES 1 A US network's political file and a weekly magazine's explainer, both 17 October 2026 and both read at source, for the signature date, the waived provisions, the certification, the White House rationale, the 2031 sunset and the April 2027 diesel licence. **This desk did not read the order itself, and the two outlets conflict on its reach — one says every operative Russian section, the other only the two tariff schedules — so the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.** 2 The same two files for the quoted legislators, Zelensky's remark and Tatiana Mitrova's analysis; the diesel observation from a US network's market file of 16 October. **Four further American outlets returned 403 or 503.** 3 Elections Alberta's own referendum and current-election pages, read at source, for the ten questions, the voting hours, the 29 October declaration and the office's refusal to interpret; Leger's October survey of 1,001 Albertans, an online non-probability panel for which **Leger itself states no margin of error can be calculated**; and the Clarity Act, S.C. 2000 c. 26, read at the Canadian justice department's site. **The verbatim tenth question sits in Order in Council 160/2026, which this desk could not reach, so it is summarised, not quoted; the 1998 Secession Reference was not read and is not relied on.** 4 The Bulgarian state news agency and a Sofia news agency, 16 and 17 October, both read at source, for the proceedings, the tow, the berth, the damage and every quotation. **The two disagree on the ship's flag, one saying Malta and one Ukraine, so this desk prints neither.** 5 The European Space Agency's mission page and an astronomy title's preview, read at source, for the launch instant, the rover, the ten-gram return and the stood-down 2024 attempt.

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE

NEA logs PSI 93 in the north at 5am, down from Sunday's 230

Three of the seven Indonesian firms served under the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act got materially identical notices in 2015. The Act allows S$100,000 a day; nothing has ever been collected.

The **National Environment Agency**'s own machine feed read **93 in the north** at five o'clock this morning — 105 south, 109 east, 119 central, **141 west** — the first regional figure under 100 since the episode began. A day earlier the west stood at **230**, the season's peak and the fourteenth straight day of unhealthy air, the longest run since 2015. But this is a wind event, not an enforcement one, and the agency warns smoke may return **from Tuesday night**.[1]

The law moved more slowly than the weather. Seven Indonesian companies were served preventive measures notices on **16 October** over the fires of the 8th and 9th, all in Sumatra. Three — **PT Bumi Andalas Permai**, **PT Bumi Mekar Hijau** and **PT SBA Wood Industries** — were served materially identical notices in **2015**. The Act permits fines of up to **S$100,000 for each day** haze occurs here and a further **S$50,000 a day** for ignoring a notice. No deadline for the action plans appears anywhere this desk could read, and minister **Grace Fu** says ownership **"cannot be disclosed at this time"**.[2]

Eleven years, two sets of notices, the same three companies, and not one dollar of the hundred thousand a day.

What the fortnight stopped was ordinary life. Education Minister **Desmond Lee** said on 16 October that O-Level papers may be rescheduled only if the forecast reaches **hazardous levels above 300**; exams otherwise sit in air-conditioned halls, and he warned that false reports of closures were circulating. ActiveSG shut outdoor venues on the 15th, the **Great Eastern Women's Run** of 17 November is cancelled, and on Saturday a dozen runners did laps inside **Marina Square**.[3]

Meanwhile the Prime Minister left for the Gulf. **Lawrence Wong** is in Qatar from **18 to 20 October** and the UAE to the 22nd; Gan Kim Yong is Acting Prime Minister. His office calls it a **"timely opportunity… to exchange views with regional leaders on developments in the Middle East"** and names energy security as the purpose. It does not say the words Strait of Hormuz — the channel through which Tehran says it passed its reopening plan to Washington (p3).[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE FORUM IS ACTUALLY ASKING

A HardwareZone thread asks whether a surgical mask is any use. *lizzykai*: **"No use need n95 cause of pm2.5 particles for haze"**. *Bardiel*: wearing one is **"the same as don wear"**. *Jurchen King* reports N95s **"sold out in many pharmacies"**; others order KF94s from Pinduoduo, one taking his advice from a chatbot. **Nobody in it mentions NEA, the Act or Indonesia.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A LAW THAT NEEDS THE NEIGHBOUR'S HELP

Jolene Lin of NUS notes the Act's 2015 use drew Indonesian complaints that Singapore **"was infringing upon Indonesia's sovereignty"**. **Michelle Lim** of SMU observes that Singapore's access to the corporate information it needs depends on what Jakarta allows. Fu's own hedge: enforcement **"will not be easy"**, but Singapore **"must try"**. Note the tense.[2]

SOURCES 1 All PSI and PM2.5 readings above were read by this desk from **the Singapore government's own open-data API**, at two independent endpoints returning identical values, for 05:00 on 19 October and 12:00 on 18 October; the season peak of 230, the fourteen-day run and NEA's 101–190 forecast and Tuesday-night warning via a Singapore news site of 17 and 18 October, read at source. **nea.gov.sg and haze.gov.sg render client-side and yielded nothing machine-readable; the API is the substitute, and it is the same agency's data.** 2 A Singapore news site's reports of 16 and 17 October, read at source, for the seven companies, the fires, the penalty schedule, Grace Fu's hedges and both academics. **The 2015 overlap is single-sourced to that outlet. No Indonesian response to the notices could be found, and this desk will not name Indonesia's environment minister: two sources give different names and the Jakarta title that would settle it returned 403.** 3 The same outlet, 16 and 17 October, for the PSI-300 contingency, the exam halls, the fake-news warning, the ActiveSG closures and the Marina Square run. **The race cancellation is single-sourced; the event's own site served no announcement.** 4 A Singapore news site's report of 17 October quoting a Prime Minister's Office statement of the same date, for the dates, the delegation, the Acting Prime Minister and the quoted purpose. **Single-sourced; the PMO statement itself was not reached.** 5 A Singapore hardware forum thread, read at source and quoted under the handles posted; it opened on 14 October and was live when read, so it is current rather than strictly weekend sentiment. **Reddit refused this desk for a fifth consecutive issue and both national broadsheets are unreachable from here, so their comment threads are out of evidence.**

THE ATELIER · PADLOCKS & CYLINDERS

ASSA ABLOY bought Sargent & Greenleaf in December 2025 and now lists 174 brands

Sold Secure's live register grades a Mul-T-Lock padlock Silver and a Squire closed-shackle Diamond. A Yale and an Abloy are the same company and not the same object.

ASSA ABLOY's own annual report records the acquisition of **Sargent & Greenleaf** in **December 2025** — the safe-lock maker stamped inside bank doors, 100 employees, **SEK 430 million**, and one of **23 strategic acquisitions in 2025 alone** by a group of **64,000 people**. Its brand directory header reads **"12 of 174"**; another page on the same site says more than 250. One owner. The first thing to know, and the least useful.[1]

What the lock is made of is more useful. A body runs from **laminated steel** — stamped plates on rivets, and the rivets are the product — through soft **brass** to **case-hardened steel**. But the step that changes the attack is not the metal: it is **open shackle to closed shackle**, the body extended up around it so no cropper jaw can seat. And "hardened" means two things: **case-hardened** drives carbon into the surface only, so a cropper cracks a brittle skin and shears a soft core; **through-hardened boron alloy** deforms the jaw first.[2]

> ***The badge tells you who banks the money. The mechanism tells you what you bought.***

Then the cylinder, where Abloy earns its name. A **disc detainer** has no pins and **no springs**: discs sit on a shaft, the key's angled bitting *rotates* each through a set number of degrees, and when every true gate aligns a sidebar drops. Emil Henriksson patented it in **1907**. Nothing is open to the keyway, so **dirt, water and salt have nowhere to jam** — and at eighty per cent humidity, fewest sprung parts wins.[3]

WHAT EACH STEP BUYS · MAKER AND DEALER LIST PRICES

TIER	LOCK	PRICE
The sweet spot	Squire SS65CS, 12.7mm boron, CEN 6	£208.99
The grail	Squire SS100CS, 20mm, 4.3kg, SR4	£484.99

Read **EN 1303's second digit** instead of the price: Grade 4 is 25,000 cycles, Grade 6 is 100,000 — at four turns a day, **seventeen years against sixty-eight**. The sixth digit is corrosion, and **0 means no requirement at all**. **The Abloy price comes from a dealer shop printing a bare dollar sign, ex-tax.**[4][5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE PICKERS ACTUALLY BUY

On Lock Picking 101 the ranking is settled, and *cledry* has the line that matters most here: **"Abloy is also much better for dirty, dusty, wet or salty environments."** Called overrated: Yale badges and interchangeable cores of any make.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY ATTACKS THE LOCK

Seattle's police put it in a bulletin: the commonest forced entry is a kick, and **"the weakest point is almost always the strike plate"**. Swap its screws for **four-inch** ones into the stud and **"this one step alone will deter or prevent most through-the-door forced entries."** *Publius*: a premium padlock on weak furniture is **"an ANSI Grade 1 deadbolt on a screen door."**[7]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Mosquito nets & bed canopies — the one tropical object with a published performance standard behind it.

Irons & steam generators — boiler pressure in bar, soleplate alloys, and a badge tax scaling with nothing.

Acoustic guitars — solid against laminate, and a top that cracks because the air changed.

SOURCES 1 ASSA ABLOY's Annual Report 2025, read at source as the company's own PDF, for the Sargent & Greenleaf acquisition and its date, employee count and consideration, the 23 strategic acquisitions, the 64,000 employees, the SEK 152,409 million sales figure, the aftermarket share and the endorsed-brand structure; the group's own brand directory for the "12 of 174" header and a second corporate page for the "more than 250" figure. **Both numbers are the company's own and they disagree, so both are printed. No lock-market share percentage is published by anyone and none is printed here.** 2 Squire's and Abloy's own product pages, read at source, for the constructions, the case-hardened and boron wordings and the open-against-closed pairs; Sold Secure's live register for the grades those locks hold. 3 A lock-mechanism reference, read at source, for the disc-detainer description, the sidebar and the 1907 invention. 4 UNION's own standards page for the EN 1303 digit table, the cycle counts and the corrosion grades. **The cycles-to-years arithmetic is this desk's, from four operations a day.** 5 Squire's own shop, with VAT, and an ASSA ABLOY-operated dealer eShop whose prices carry a bare dollar sign and exclude tax; Bowley's own store in US dollars. 6 Two Lock Picking 101 threads, read at source and quoted under the handles posted. **Reddit refused this desk for a fifth consecutive issue, so r/lockpicking and r/locksmith are out of evidence; keypicking.com was re-checked and still serves a gambling-affiliate site, as No. 130 reported.** 7 A Seattle Police Department bulletin, read at source as its own PDF. **Held: no Singapore insurer was found specifying any lock grade, and PUB's list of patented lock suppliers could not be read — pub.gov.sg refused this desk, as at No. 134.**

TECHNOLOGY · CHINA'S EXPORT LIST

China drafts export curbs on open-weight AI models above two trillion parameters

The 16 October draft covers forty technologies and keeps the open-source carve-out — as an automatic licence Beijing can revoke. Comments close on 15 November.

China's commerce and science ministries jointly published a draft export-control list on **Friday 16 October**. Forty technologies are proposed: **23 in artificial intelligence**, twelve in solar, five in biomedicine. The AI threshold is explicit. Controls would cover the weights, source code and core components of any model with **at least two trillion parameters**, or ranking **in the global top ten** on performance and safety tests. Design know-how for chips at **14 nanometres or below** is in scope, and exporting a model trained on sensitive national data is banned outright. Comments close **15 November**; until then none of it is law.[1]

What makes this a delta rather than a repeat of the ministry's earlier listing (No. 136) is one footnote. A reader on Hacker News who wanted to check what the draft said found it published in **WPS Office format** — proprietary Chinese office software — and had to install it first. Having done so, **yorwba** reported that the text promises automatic permission for open-source releases. But firms above the threshold **must report in advance** to get that licence, **and it can be revoked** if the authorities decide a capability should not be given away free.[2]

An exemption has become a permission slip. The difference only shows up the first time it is withdrawn.

Taipei is moving the other way on the same week's clock and with less to show. Economy minister **Kung Ming-hsin** said Taiwan will add **AI servers and advanced semiconductors** to its controlled-items list, so that **"some of our measures on controlled items will correspond to American ones"** under the reciprocal trade agreement signed this year. Once in force, shipping restricted AI hardware to China becomes a criminal offence under Taiwan's Foreign Trade Act; today it is not. He gave **no effective date and no threshold**. It is an intention, not yet a rule.[3]

2 trillion

PARAMETER THRESHOLD ABOVE WHICH A MODEL'S WEIGHTS WOULD NEED AN EXPORT LICENCE[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT BEIJING ACTUALLY WANTS

The read on Hacker News is not soft power. *alephnerd* calls the two-trillion rule **"huge"** and argues the goal is commercial: **"They just want to monetize and scale out their hyperscalers"** and split the two AI ecosystems apart. *jauntywundrkind*, more briefly: **"GLM-5.3 forever. Well shit."** Bloomberg and the Associated Press are reported to have named Moonshot's Kimi K3 and Alibaba's Qwen3.8-Max as already above the line — read here at one remove.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · DISTRIBUTION, NOT WEIGHTS

porridgeraisin, in the same thread, argues the strategy misreads the market: Chinese software has weak global distribution and rarely ships first inside enterprise products, so closing off self-hosting will not push users onto Chinese clouds while Salesforce, Amazon and Stripe own the channel. And the sharpest objection is textual. The same reader who installed WPS Office found the **deepfake-detection thresholds apparently printed backwards** — banned above 95 per cent precision and recall, merely restricted above 98 — evidence, he writes, that the draft **"needs work"**.[2]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Beijing's stated purpose. The ministry says the rules aim to **"prevent misuse and abuse"** and to **"ensure that AI remains under human control"**, and that they target no country or company.[1]

SOURCES 1 A technology news site's report of the draft and a Bangladeshi business daily's wire file of 18 October, both read at source, for the 16 October publication, the forty technologies and their split across AI, solar and biomedicine, the two-trillion-parameter and global-top-ten thresholds, the 14-nanometre and stacking criteria, the outright ban on models trained on sensitive national data, the 15 November comment deadline and both ministry quotations. **The Financial Times and Wall Street Journal also covered it on 16 October; both are paywalled and were not read.** 2 Two Hacker News threads of 16 and 17 October, read at source and quoted under the handles posted, for the WPS Office format, the reader's reading of the automatic-but-revocable licence, the advance-reporting requirement, the apparently inverted deepfake thresholds, and the quoted judgements. **The naming of specific Chinese models as above the threshold is attributed by that thread to Bloomberg and the Associated Press; this desk did not read either, and prints it at one remove.** 3 A financial portal's report of 16 October carrying a Bloomberg interview of 12 October, read at source, for the minister's name and quotation, the items, the criminal-liability change under the Foreign Trade Act and the absence of a date; a security brief of the same day corroborates the criminal penalties. **That brief names no official, no threshold and no timeline, and concedes the link to the trade pact is asserted rather than documented. No community discussion of the Taiwanese measure exists on Hacker News, and Reddit refused this desk for a fifth consecutive issue, so none is invented here.**

THE HOME LAB · PS5LM

PS5LM runs a 27-billion-parameter model on a jailbroken PlayStation 5

The repository reports about 20 tokens a second at 64k context from 11.4GB of shared memory. Separately, llama.cpp merged a Hugging Face model browser on 17 October.

A developer publishing as **cobanov** released **PS5LM** this week: llama.cpp built for a jailbroken PlayStation 5, serving GGUF models over the home network behind OpenAI- and Anthropic-compatible APIs. The README's own claim is that it **"needs no PC while it runs, no cloud and no account"**. It wants firmware between 7.00 and 13.60 and three payloads. About **11.4GB** of the console's shared memory is available for model and context.[1]

The measured figures, on a PS5 Slim: **Qwen 3.5 0.8B** at Q4_K_M, **207 tokens a second**; **Qwen 3.5 9B** at the same quantisation, **55**; and **Qwen 3.8 27B** squeezed to a two-bit UD-Q2_K_XL at 9.2GB, about **20 tokens a second at 64k context**. They are the author's own numbers and there is no third-party benchmark — but a commenter on Hacker News independently reports roughly the same twenty, and the thread took **372 points and 85 comments** in two days. A secondhand console is the hardware, and one estimate in the thread puts the electricity at about **70 cents a day** for two million output tokens.[2]

The most discussed local-inference machine of the week was not a workstation. It was a games console somebody had already paid for.

The week's other merge matters more to anyone running a rig properly. **llama.cpp** pulled in **PR 29584** on **17 October**, adding a Hugging Face model browser to the web interface: search and browse GGUF repositories, per-quantisation download buttons that show whether the file will fit in memory, pause-and-resume downloads that survive a server restart, and automatic fetching of a matching draft model as a sub-line rather than a separate row. It ships in build **b11714** and it is **off by default** — which is the maintainers' own verdict on its maturity.[3]

11.4 GB

SHARED MEMORY A JAILBROKEN PS5 MAKES AVAILABLE FOR MODEL WEIGHTS AND CONTEXT[1]

THE CHATTER · USEFUL, WITH CAVEATS

none_to_remain reports about twenty tokens a second himself and calls the two-bit model limited but useful for reading codebases, where a typo matters less. *thombles* finds the 27B **"surprisingly effective"** but notes it spends tens of thousands of tokens reasoning, so at low tens of tokens a second the wait is long. On cost, *shiftpgdn* paid about **$150 shipped** for a BC-250 board plus $40 to $50 in parts — the console's nearest rival for the money.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO BITS IS TWO BITS

hypfer calls it **"entirely useless given the limited VRAM"** and says the README oversells. *kadoban*: two-bit is noticeably worse than four-bit and will not replace a frontier model for most people — offered explicitly from memory, not from benchmarks. The honest frame is that this is a **$200 machine doing a $200 machine's work**, well, and that the enthusiast conversation this weekend was about a console rather than about any vendor's launch.[2]

IN BRIEF · THE BENCH

Nvidia's RTX Spark laptops shipped on 16 October from eight makers, from **US$2,599**, pairing a Blackwell GPU and a Grace CPU with up to 128GB of unified memory. The number the release omits is the one that governs inference: ServeTheHome measured the memory bus at about **300GB/s** — less than half an RTX 5070's — and notes the CPU uses stock 2024 Arm cores. **Nemotron 3.5 Bolt**, 74B at two bits in 24GB, is the on-device model; Nvidia still publishes no tokens per second for it (Nos. 134, 136).[4]

SOURCES 1 The PS5LM repository README, read at source — for the architecture, the firmware range and payloads, the 11.4GB shared-memory figure, the context planner and the quoted claim. The project is GPL-3.0-or-later; its author gives no real name. 2 A Hacker News thread of 16 October, read at source and quoted under the handles posted, for the independent twenty-tokens-a-second report, the point and comment counts, the cost comparison and every sceptical remark. **The electricity estimate is a commenter's own arithmetic, not a measurement, and is printed as such. All the speed figures in the table above are the author's; no independent benchmark of PS5LM has been published.** 3 Pull request 29584 in the llama.cpp repository and the project's release list, both read at source, for the merge date, the feature set, the default-off setting and the build tag. The maintainers' review found real defects before merge — shared files that could be deleted on cancellation, and resume regressions — which is where the scepticism about this feature properly lives. 4 Nvidia's own press release of 16 October for the launch, the eight makers, the memory ceiling and the US$2,599 entry price, and a hardware site's overview of 17 October for the measured memory bandwidth and the Arm core generation, both read at source; Nvidia's developer blog of 13 October for the Nemotron model's parameters and quantisation. **Singapore availability and pricing for these machines could not be established for a fourth consecutive issue: the vendor's Singapore store returned 503 and its business page 404.**

THE KIT · APPLE'S IPHONE DUO

Apple opened iPhone Duo pre-orders in Singapore at S$3,099 and sold out

Shipping estimates slipped to around 25 January within half an hour. Bloomberg's Mark Gurman: "Apple made a major mistake here."

Apple opened pre-orders for its first folding iPhone at **eight o'clock on Friday evening** in Singapore, with the phone in shops on **Friday 23 October**. Read on Apple's own Singapore store, the prices are **S$3,099** for 256GB, **S$3,399** for 512GB, **S$3,999** for a terabyte and **S$4,899** for two, GST included, the same in both Star White and Night Sky, **limit two per customer**. Trade-in credit runs S$230 to S$1,615 for an iPhone 13 or newer. In the United States Apple published a lease at **$57.99 a month** over two years and, characteristically, no outright price at all.[1]

The object: a **7.6-inch** inner folding OLED, a **5.4-inch** outer screen, the **A20 Pro** with a vapour chamber, a Grade 5 titanium frame, **5.2mm open and 11.3mm closed at 254 grams**, IP68. Two 48-megapixel cameras, with the 2× telephoto done as a sensor crop rather than a lens. There is **no SIM tray** and **no Action button**. Apple claims up to 31 hours of video on the inner display. The repair position is the part to read twice: replacing the folding screen reportedly costs about what a new iPhone does.[2]

> ***A phone you can pay for tonight and hold in late January is a pre-order in the oldest sense: a queue with a receipt.***

What happened next is the actual story. Inside **thirty minutes** of pre-orders opening, estimated delivery across most countries had slipped to around **25 January**. Apple had opened in **more than seventy countries at once**, having originally planned the United States and China only — and, according to Bloomberg's **Mark Gurman**, knew supply would be severely constrained and went ahead anyway, apparently to land the launch inside its fiscal first quarter. Retail staff have reportedly been told to warn against walk-in purchases.[3]

S$3,099

SINGAPORE PRICE OF THE 256GB IPHONE DUO, READ ON APPLE'S OWN STORE[1]

THE CHATTER · NOBODY IS TALKING ABOUT THE PHONE

The Hacker News thread on the sell-out ran to 37 points and 21 comments, and almost none of it is about folding screens. *wtallis* notes every colour and capacity shows **25 January or later**. *joshstrange* ordered two minutes after opening and got November. *stevenhubertron* has tried to get excited and can see no use case beyond the devices he owns. Most of the rest is an argument about whether complaining of a sold-out two-thousand-dollar phone is whining. **Scarcity theatre, not product enthusiasm.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE CASE STICKS ON WITH GLUE

Two details sit awkwardly beside the price. Apple's own **$79** iPhone Duo case attaches with **adhesive**, there being no uniform back to grip. And for a reader who buys once and keeps: a folding display is a consumable with a hinge, the telephoto is a crop rather than an optic, and the screen repair is priced like a replacement handset. **None of that is a reason not to want one. All of it is a reason not to queue.**[2]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Nvidia's RTX Spark laptops went on sale globally on 16 October from **US$2,599** across eight makers — the buying numbers and the bandwidth caveat are on p8. Compact RTX Spark desktops are promised for **November**, which is a forecast, not a date.[4]

Nothing else cleared the bar this week. Apple's HomeView (No. 135), Amazon's Bee Frontier (No. 136) and Ray-Ban Meta Audio all landed before this window. This desk would rather run two items it read than three it guessed.

SOURCES 1 Apple's Singapore online store, read at source by this desk, for all four Singapore prices, the GST note, the two-per-customer limit, both colours and the 23 October availability; a Singapore consumer site of 16 October for the 8pm pre-order opening and the trade-in range; Apple's own newsroom announcement of 15 October for the US lease terms. **Apple publishes no outright US purchase price on that page.** 2 Apple's newsroom announcement, read at source, for every dimension, material, display, camera, battery and connectivity figure above — all of them the manufacturer's own, none independently measured. The repair-cost and adhesive-case points come from a US technology title of 14 October and a Mac news site's index of 16 October; **the second was read as a headline only, and is printed with that hedge.** 3 A Mac news site's report of 18 October summarising Bloomberg's *Power On* newsletter, read at source, for the thirty-minute sell-out, the 25 January estimates, the seventy-country launch, the original two-country plan and the quoted judgement; a Hacker News thread of 16 October for all commenter remarks, quoted under the handles posted. **Reddit refused this desk for a fifth consecutive issue.** 4 Nvidia's press release of 16 October, read at source. **Singapore pricing and availability for the Surface Laptop Ultra remain unestablished for a fourth week; the vendor's Singapore store returned 503.**

THE GOOD LIFE · ORIS PROPILOT

Oris relaunches the ProPilot Calibre 111 with a ten-day hand-wound movement

CHF 6,100 on the steel bracelet, 43mm across and 13.2mm thick, with 240 hours of running from a mainspring 1.8 metres long. No Singapore price yet.

Oris brought back the ProPilot Calibre 111 on **16 October**, eleven years after the original, in four references: black or pine-green dial, Cordovan leather or steel bracelet. The prices the maker publishes are **CHF 6,100** on the bracelet and **CHF 5,900** on the strap. **No Singapore price has been published**, and a US figure circulating at $7,400 comes from a title that refused this desk, so it is held rather than printed. The case has come down in both directions that matter — **43mm** from 44, **13.2mm** thick from over 14 — with 51mm lug to lug, a fluted bezel, screw-down crown and 100 metres of water resistance.[1]

The movement is the argument. The in-house **Calibre 111** is **manually wound** and runs **240 hours** — ten days — from a single mainspring **1.8 metres long**, with the reserve shown on a deliberately non-linear scale at three o'clock, small seconds at nine and the date moved down to six. Thirty-seven jewels, five-year warranty on registration. This desk will not print a beat rate: the two specialist titles read give **28,800 and 21,600 vibrations an hour**, and a watch cannot have both.[2]

Ten days in a steel case, from a spring the length of a dining table, wound by hand. That is the whole proposition.

For a buy-once reader the question is not whether it is handsome — it is — but what the ten days buy. A hand-wound ten-day calibre asks the owner to turn a crown once a week and never to worry about a watch left in a drawer. What it costs is thickness, complexity and the regulation problem of keeping torque even across a spring that long. Against the usual comparison, a reader on Monochrome put the value case bluntly: it will **"give the IWC Portugieser a run for its money at half the price"**.[3]

240 hours

POWER RESERVE FROM ONE 1.8-METRE MAINSPRING, WOUND BY HAND[1]

THE CHATTER · THE COMMENT THREADS LIKE IT

Twenty-two comments across the two specialist sites in three days, and the balance is warm. *Davkis11* calls it **"stunning and unique"**; *srmgin* likes the dial, the size and the reserve and finds the price fair; *TO-OB* thinks it a touch bigger than needed but the proportions perfect; *Victor777* is tempted, and defends the calibre's isochronism against the doubters below.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · OWNERS ON THE PRICE AND THE POINT

The pushback comes from people who already own the brand. *BG*, with three Oris watches, thinks **$7,300 is too much**; *A* says Oris has moved too far up the price ladder. *MarkBu* questions the point of a ten-day *manual* winder over a rotor, and of small seconds on a tool watch. *Tam O'Banter*: the 240-hour calibre adds expense, complexity and bulk without enough benefit. Several call 43mm too large, and the reviewer himself finds **20mm lugs narrow for a 43mm case** — the previous 22mm was better proportioned.[3]

HELD, AND WHY

WatchTime New York ran 16–18 October at Gotham Hall, and this desk can tell you nothing about it with confidence. The launch prices circulating from that fair — a six-figure Jacob & Co. limited edition, a Frederique Constant perpetual, a Blancpain, a Citizen anniversary piece — appear only in search-result text. **The organiser's own site returned 403 to three separate requests and a trade title returned 403 as well, so none of it was read at source and none of it is printed here as fact.**

SOURCES 1 A Swiss-watch specialist title's introduction of ~16 October 2026, read at source, for the four reference numbers, both Swiss-franc prices, the case dimensions, the bezel, crown and water resistance, the 240-hour reserve, the 1.8-metre mainspring, the non-linear scale, the jewel count, the dial finishes and the immediate, permanent availability. 2 A second specialist title of 16 October, read at source, independently confirming both prices, 43mm, 13.2mm, 51mm lug-to-lug, the 240-hour reserve, 100m, 20mm lugs, the five-year warranty and the date's move from nine to six, and dating the original model to 2015. **The two disagree on the beat rate — 28,800 against 21,600 vibrations an hour — so this desk prints neither figure. The US dollar prices in circulation come from a title that returned 403 and are held. No Singapore retail price is published by anyone.** 3 The reader comment threads beneath both articles, 16 to 18 October, read at source and quoted under the handles posted. **Watchuseek was not reached this week, so nothing here is attributed to it; the value comparison to a German competitor is one reader's opinion, printed as such.** The product photograph in the screen edition is that specialist title's own, opened and examined by this desk before it was captioned.

SCREEN & SOUND · ELIZABETH HOLMES

A24's Elizabeth Holmes documentary opens at Metascore 99 and $15m

"You Can See Everything" took $15m from 855 screens against Street Fighter's $31m from 3,575 — twice the take per screen, for a film of two hours fifty-four.

A24 released **You Can See Everything** on **Friday 16 October** and it opened second at the American box office with **$15 million from 855 theatres**. Directed by **Nathan Fielder** and **Lance Oppenheim**, it follows **Elizabeth Holmes** through the thirty-four days before she goes to prison; the project ran three years. Rated R, **two hours fifty-four**. Metacritic puts it at **99 from 37 critics**, every one positive; Rotten Tomatoes at **99 per cent from 115**. Those are the numbers of a film nobody wants to doubt first.[1]

The weekend belonged on paper to **Street Fighter**, which took **$31 million from 3,575 screens** for Paramount on a **Metascore of 44** from 26 critics — four positive, sixteen mixed, six negative — and 42 per cent at Rotten Tomatoes against a **79 per cent audience score**. Work the two openings per screen and the documentary took about **$17,500** a screen to the fighting game's **$8,700**; that is this desk's arithmetic from the published grosses, not a figure anyone publishes. **No Singapore release date for the documentary could be established.**[2]

A three-hour documentary outsold a video-game adaptation two to one on every screen it played.

Friday was also the year's largest release day for records, and it settles something this book has been carrying. **Richard Thompson**'s *Hippies, Thugs And Heroes* leads the week at **Metascore 96** — the highest score of the week in any medium bar the A24 film. **Dummy**'s *Do You Love The Color Of The Sky?* sits at 87, **The Avalanches**' *No Bad Memories* at 81, Eels at 81, Rachel Chinouriri at 77. And **Fontaines D.C.**'s *Dopamine Chamber*, held across two issues, now reads **85**, read on Metacritic by this desk.[3]

99 / 37

METASCORE AND CRITIC COUNT FOR "YOU CAN SEE EVERYTHING", WITH NO NEGATIVE REVIEW[1]

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT IS ABOUT HER, NOT IT

A Hacker News thread ran to **337 points and 458 comments** and is almost entirely about Holmes rather than the film. *hypersoar* insists Theranos ran unreliable tests on real patients, not merely defrauded investors, and notes that **Balwani was convicted on the patient-fraud charges Holmes was acquitted of**. *erulabs*: **"Important to note she was found not guilty of this charge."** *phire* presses the point as law rather than innocence. *siliconc0w* argues the investors failed their own due diligence.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ONE REVIEW THAT FIGHTS THE 99

Polina Pompliano, writing on **16 October**, argues the film manipulates its audience into shifting its view of Holmes while letting it believe it arrived there alone. **"They did it through camera angles, close-ups, editing, and the order in which information was revealed"**; the viewer, she writes, comes to **"discover that you're also watching a demonstration of how easy it is to deceive you"**. Her sharpest line is about the director: **"Does he care a bit too much for Elizabeth that he's willing to lie to the viewer?"**[5]

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT

No. 136 reported *Dopamine Chamber*'s Metascore as held. It is **85**, read on Metacritic this morning — and the record now agrees with what No. 135 printed before the correction chain began. **What stays held:** critic counts for every album above, because Metacritic's individual album pages returned 403 on every attempt and its browse page prints scores without them; and **Billboard unit figures**, unresolved for a third issue.[3]

SOURCES 1 Metacritic's film page and Rotten Tomatoes' page for *You Can See Everything*, both read at source, for the two aggregate scores and both critic counts, the release date, certificate, running time, directors and synopsis; Box Office Mojo's weekend chart for 16–18 October 2026 for the gross and theatre count. All weekend grosses are **estimates**, as that chart states. 2 The same weekend chart for *Street Fighter*'s gross and screens; Metacritic and Rotten Tomatoes for its scores, critic counts and the positive/mixed/negative split. **The per-screen figures are this desk's own division of those published grosses and are labelled as such.** 3 Metacritic's new-releases browse page, read at source this morning, for every album score printed above, all dated 16 October 2026. **That page publishes no critic counts, and the individual album pages returned 403 on every attempt, as did a second aggregator — so the counts are held rather than guessed. No Billboard unit figures could be read for a third consecutive issue.** 4 A Hacker News thread of 18 October, read at source and quoted under the handles posted. **Reddit refused this desk for a fifth consecutive issue, so no subreddit sentiment appears anywhere in this issue.** 5 A media newsletter's essay of 16 October, read at source, for all three quotations and the argument. **Two further critical pieces, in a US daily and a US paper's opinion section, are paywalled and were not read.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE LANCET SERIES

NUS researchers co-wrote the Lancet's new paper on children's digital media

Published 4 October, it models 2.8 million healthy years lost to depression. Professor Alan Woodward counters that 71 per cent of the 121 underlying reviews were rated low quality.

The Lancet published a three-paper Series on the digital determinants of health on **Sunday 4 October 2026**, and the second paper is substantially a Singapore document: **four of its six named authors**, including **Padmapriya Natarajan** and **Falk Müller-Riemenschneider**, are at the **Saw Swee Hock School of Public Health** at NUS. It rests on an umbrella review of **121 reviews**, and its headline number is a model: **2.8 million healthy years of life lost to depression**, which the authors hedge themselves as substantial **"even as its causal basis remains uncertain"**.[1]

The hedge is the argument, and five named academics said so within hours. **Alan Woodward**, professor of cybersecurity at Surrey: **"The 2.8 million and 240,000 figures show what the burden would be if the association with screen time were entirely causal"** — and, more sharply, **"Calling for precautionary action is a legitimate position, but it is a value judgement, not a scientific finding."** He is the one who counted the quality ratings: **71 per cent of the 121 reviews were rated low or critically low**. **Teodora Gliga** of East Anglia calls the conclusion **"both exaggerated and necessary"**, and is blunt that **"This reviewed evidence does not tell us that screen time causes depression or autism/ADHD."** **Myles Jones** of Sheffield: the papers are **"essentially opinion pieces"**.[2]

> ***A value judgement, not a scientific finding — and the paper's own authors say the causal basis remains uncertain.***

What survives both readings is the part a parent can use. The paper names **developmental stage** as an important moderator: the band matters more than the aggregate, which is the opposite of how screen-time advice is usually given. **Lizzy Winstone** of Bristol points the same way, arguing the focus should move off total screen time and onto platform design and commercial practice — a question about what the app is doing, not how long it is open.[2]

71%

OF THE 121 REVIEWS BEHIND THE SERIES RATED LOW OR CRITICALLY LOW QUALITY[2]

THE CHATTER · ANXIETY, AND WHO IS NOT TREATED

A second paper, in *JAMA Pediatrics* on **12 October**, surveyed **15,730 American adolescents aged 12 to 20** — a band whose floor is exactly her age. Moderate anxiety symptoms: **13.4 per cent of girls against 6.0 of boys**; severe, **10.8 against 3.7**. The number that should travel is the last: **41.2 per cent of the severely symptomatic received no mental-health treatment at all** in the previous year. **The published abstract gives counts and percentages only, with no effect sizes or confidence intervals, so none are printed here.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A COHORT THAT DOES NOT CONTAIN HER

The week's other widely-covered paper, on caffeine and adolescent brain structure, studied **nearly 10,000 children aged 9 to 11** — a cohort that **does not contain a twelve-year-old**, which is why this desk is not running it as advice. Its own reviewers agree: **Derek Hill** of UCL says **"The conclusions of the paper should be considered speculative"**, and **Charalampos Rallis** of Queen Mary adds that **"The association with later mental health is negligible."**[4]

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

Nothing on this desk is a clinical recommendation. Singapore's live school policy is still the **30 November 2025** announcement — a whole-school-day ban on smartphones and smartwatches in secondary schools from January 2026, with the default learning-device lock moved to 10.30pm. **No October move by the education or health ministries could be verified: the ministry's own press index returned nothing to this desk, so the November rule is reported as standing, not as new.**

SOURCES 1 *The Lancet*, Series on the digital determinants of health, paper two, published 4 October 2026 — **read as the indexed abstract from the US National Library of Medicine, because thelancet.com returned 403 to this desk** — for the authorship and affiliations, the 121-review evidence base, the modelled figure, the developmental-stage finding and the quoted hedge. 2 The Science Media Centre's expert reaction of 4 October 2026, read at source, for all four named academics, their titles and every quotation, and for the 71 per cent quality rating. 3 *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 12 October 2026, read at source, for the sample, the age range, every percentage and the untreated shares. **The abstract carries no effect sizes or confidence intervals and none are invented here.** 4 The Science Media Centre's expert reaction of 15 October 2026, read at source. **Neither No. 135's twin study nor No. 136's phone trial is re-run here.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · SCHOOL START TIMES

Teenagers in California slept 38 minutes longer after the state moved school start times

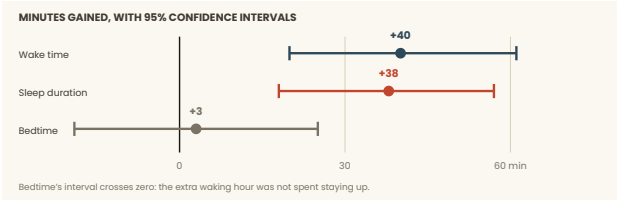
A JAMA Network Open research letter of 12 October, 724 youths aged 12 to 21, confidence interval 18 to 57 minutes. Bedtimes did not move at all.

Lu Dong of Stony Brook and **Wendy Troxel** of RAND published a research letter in JAMA *Network Open* on **12 October 2026** comparing Californian adolescents, who live under a state law mandating later school start times, with those elsewhere. The Californians woke **40 minutes later** and slept **38 minutes longer**; their bedtimes were statistically unchanged. The sample is **724 young people aged 12 to 21**, mean age 16.3, from a 2024 national panel.[1]

The objection parents raise to a later bell is that teenagers simply stay up later and bank nothing. This is the measurement of that objection, and it does not hold: the extra forty minutes of waking came through almost intact. Daytime sleepiness, though, did not shift measurably — odds ratio **0.79**, CI 0.47 to 1.33, which crosses one. More sleep, not yet demonstrably less tired.[1]

A twelve-year-old sits at the best point on this curve. From here it only gets later and shorter.

The line worth keeping is the age gradient buried in the same letter: each additional year brought a **later bedtime** and **shorter sleep**. A twelve-year-old is at the favourable end of that slope and will travel down it for six years whatever any ministry does about bells — which makes the habits set now, where the phone charges and when the lights go, the part a household controls. The authors are explicit that the design **cannot establish causation**.[1]



Meridian original, plotted from the research letter's published point estimates and 95% confidence intervals.[1]

+38 min

EXTRA SLEEP FOR CALIFORNIAN ADOLESCENTS, 95% CONFIDENCE INTERVAL 18 TO 57 MINUTES[1]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE'S OWN CHILDREN, MEASURED

A Singapore study this month put **726 local children** through a physical-literacy assessment and found **72.8 per cent in the lower bins**. Income was not associated; higher maternal education was. **The caveat, and this desk keeps making it: the cohort's mean age is 11.0 years, so it tops out below twelve.** Local colour, not guidance for her year group.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A TRIAL THAT READS BETTER IN ITS SUMMARY

A cluster-randomised trial in JAMA *Network Open* on **9 October**, 437 children aged 8 to 13 across eleven Massachusetts sites, reports an adjusted zBMI difference of **−0.19** (CI −0.38 to −0.01, P = .04). But the **unadjusted** difference was **−0.14**, CI −0.29 to 0.01, **P = .07 — not significant**, and the beverage outcomes did not separate. The key-points box reads more confidently than the numbers do.[3]

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

Every figure on this page is an association from an observational or partially-adjusted design, reported with the interval its authors published. None of it is a clinical recommendation, and none of it should displace a doctor who has met the child.

SOURCES 1 *JAMA Network Open*, research letter published 12 October 2026, read at source, for both named authors, the sample size and age range, the mean age, the panel and weighting, and every effect with its confidence interval — wake time, sleep duration, bedtime, the middle-and-high-school subgroup, the sleepiness odds ratio and both age-gradient coefficients — and for the authors' own statement that the design cannot establish causation. 2 *Journal of Exercise Science & Fitness*, October 2026, read at source, for the sample, the 72.8 per cent figure, the correlation and the income and maternal-education findings. **Its cohort has a mean age of 11.0 years and is flagged here as not containing the age band this desk writes for.** 3 *JAMA Network Open*, published 9 October 2026, read at source, for the trial registration, the sites, the enrolled and analysed numbers, the age range, retention, and **both the adjusted and unadjusted primary results with their intervals and P values**. The unadjusted result is printed because the paper's summary box does not lead with it.

THE MACRO DESK · THE PARADOX DAY

American producer prices rose 1.3% in September and the Treasury 30-year yield fell

Brent gained 9.6 per cent in seven sessions to $109.86 while the US 10-year fell 15 basis points to 5.09 — the third consecutive issue it has fallen by exactly that.

On **Thursday 15 October** the Bureau of Labor Statistics reported September producer prices up **1.3 per cent on the month and 6.3 on the year**. The price of thirty-year American government money went **down**. The 10-year fell 9 basis points that day, closing the week at **5.09**. That is the regime in one session: with the terminal capped, an oil shock stops being an inflation story and becomes a demand-destruction story.[1]

The sequence is short. The Fed **raised** by 25 basis points on **16 September** to **3.75–4.00 per cent**, its first increase since July 2023, noting that **"Inflation remains elevated"**. Through early October the market traded the Hormuz disruption purely as inflation: Brent ran from **$100.20 on 7 October to $109.86 on the 16th**, and the Energy Information Administration lifted its fourth-quarter forecast to **$105**, **"$14/b higher than last month's forecast"**. Then **John Williams** capped the terminal on 13 October.[2]

The curve has changed direction, and the previous two issues read it the other way. **2s10s has flattened from +44 to +35 basis points**, the 30-year falling 17bp against the 2-year's 6 — bull flattening around a capped terminal, not the steepening this desk described a week ago. **MAS held** its band on **14 October** despite third-quarter growth of **5.4 per cent** and core inflation back at **2.1**.[3]

THE BOARD · FRIDAY 16 OCTOBER CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	WEEK
VWRA	$191.68	▼ 0.94%
US 10-year	5.09%	▼ 15bp
DXY	101.84	▼ 0.36%
Brent	$109.86	▲ 4.91%
Gold	$4,181.10	▼ 0.83%
Bitcoin	$82,156	▲ 0.58%
STI	5,415.53	▲ 0.25%

Weekly moves against 9 October. The STI sits **5.0 per cent below its 6 October peak**. Not investment advice.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

Global equities are derating quietly rather than selling off, and the bond leg did its diversifying work: the equity-bond correlation is helping again, which it was not in September. **Gold** is the anomaly — real yields fell, normally gold-positive, and it fell anyway, which reads as a structural bid already in the price. **Bitcoin** reads the liquidity side badly: $86,490 on 5 October, $82,156 on the 16th.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · A STRATEGIST WHO CALLED IT BACKWARDS

Ian Lyngen of BMO wrote on **8 October** that **"The market remains content to trade the energy shock solely from the perspective of the inflationary implications"** — his point being that demand destruction was ignored. Eight days later it did the opposite. Against the reading that yields have peaked, **Allen Sinai** calls it **"a sea change in the fundamentals"**.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Bureau of Labor Statistics' own September producer-price and consumer-price releases of 15 and 14 October 2026, read at source. Treasury yields are from **the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file, downloaded and read row by row**, with every change computed against its 9 October row. 2 The Federal Reserve's own statement of 16 September 2026, read at source, for the increase, the range, the vote and the quotation; the Energy Information Administration's *Short-Term Energy Outlook* of 6 October for the Brent forecast and its quoted revision; the New York Fed president's 13 October remarks as reported. 3 The Monetary Authority of Singapore's own statement of 14 October 2026, read at source. 4 VWRA and AGGU from the London Stock Exchange's own instrument interface, cross-checked against a second service; DXY, Brent, gold and the STI from a market data interface; USD/SGD from **the European Central Bank's own daily reference rates**; bitcoin from a daily series. **The usual daily-history service reset every one of eight connections again, as it did for the last three issues, and served a proof-of-work wall on the two that landed; iShares, the LBMA, the SGX interface, CNBC and MAS's own data service all refused this desk. A federal spot-oil series prints Brent some $20 above the futures strip for the same day; this desk uses the futures and says so.** 5 A strategist's 8 October note via a markets wire file, and the Decision Economics quotation from a markets report of 11 October, both read at source. **Forecasts are flagged as forecasts, nothing here is investment advice, and no level above was printed that could not be read at source.**

THE INVITATION · NISHIKIGOI

Nishikigoi exports from Japan reached 9.97 billion yen in 2025, up 37.9 per cent

China's imports rose 724.6 per cent in a single year. Of roughly 200,000 carp spawned, Japan's own transport ministry says 500 to 1,000 reach adulthood.

Koi keeping is not fishkeeping with a bigger tank. It is **water engineering with a fish as the output**, and three facts do the work. The first is that **the fish grows to its water**: a dealer's *tosai*, koi born this year, already run **32 to 52 centimetres**, and a Momotaro two-year-old of the Kamuy bloodline often measures **70 to 75**. Japan's transport ministry records that koi live **thirty to forty years**. No aquarium produces that. A mud pond does.[1]

The second is the cull, and it is the number to carry out of this desk. The same ministry document states that of approximately **200,000 carp spawned, only 500 to 1,000 reach adulthood**. Every fish in every dealer's vat is the survivor of a **99.7 per cent** selection. The third is that the constraint is bioload, not volume: working guidance is about **a thousand litres per adult fish**, with 3,000 litres the absolute floor for three to five small ones and 15,000 the beginning of serious keeping.[2]

Two hundred thousand spawned. Five hundred sold. The hobby's whole aesthetic rests on a cull its own government publishes.

The mechanism is a chain, and a reader who holds it can judge any pond cold. **Bottom drain** first: koi waste sinks, and a surface pump cannot lift what is on the floor. Then **settlement and mechanical**, because solids must leave before the biology or they rot inside it — which is what a **drum filter** is. Then **biological**, media at ten to fifteen per cent of pond volume. Then the stage beginners miss: **oxygen**. Nitrifying bacteria are aerobic and at koi bioload they compete with the fish for it, which is why the **bakki shower** exists — water pumped up and dropped through stacked ceramic trays.[3]

Then turnover, and here the trade is worth distrusting. The rule is the whole volume once an hour, faster in the tropics. Evolution Aqua rates its Nexus 220+ for a pond of up to **18,000 litres** at a *recommended* flow of **6,000 litres an hour** — a three-hour turnover at its own headline capacity. **Manufacturer maxima are generous. Divide them.**[4]

¥9.97bn

JAPAN'S 2025 NISHIKIGOI EXPORTS, 378 TONNES, UP 37.9% ON THE YEAR[5]

THE CHATTER · WHO IS ACTUALLY BUYING

Read against volume, the export table says something nobody in the hobby says aloud. The **United States** took ¥2.67bn across 59 tonnes; **China ¥2.34bn across 55, up 724.6 per cent in one year**; the **United Kingdom ¥0.58bn across 37**. Per kilo that is about **¥45,254**, **¥42,545** and **¥15,676**. Britain buys tonnage; America and China buy quality. **The per-kilo figures are this desk's arithmetic on the ministry's own value and volume pairs.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A RECORD THAT HAS STOOD EIGHT YEARS

The famous number is **S Legend**, a 101cm female Kohaku bred at the Sakai farm in Hiroshima, reported sold for **203 million yen** in 2018 after winning the All Japan the previous year. The British koi expert **Tim Waddington** called it **"a record price paid for a single Koi Carp"**, against a previous mark around €400,000. But the coverage disagrees with itself: one account places the buyer in Japan in one sentence and Taiwan in the next, neither gives a sale date or an auction, and the yen figure reaches English only through a single newspaper chain. **No later sale has displaced it. The record is eight years old.**[6]

SOURCES 1 A Hawaii dealer's current tosai listings and a New Jersey dealer's Momotaro page, both read at source, for the first- and second-year sizes and the Kamuy bloodline; Japan's Ministry of Land, Infrastructure, Transport and Tourism, *Nishikigoi Breeding, Hobbyists, and Shows*, **downloaded and read as the ministry's own document**, for maturity and lifespan. 2 The same ministry document for the spawn-to-adult figures; **the 99.7 per cent is this desk's arithmetic on them**. Stocking and volume guidance from a Singapore aquascaping firm's care guide — **a commercial source, flagged as such wherever it is used on these pages**. 3 A UK koi specialist's technical notes and the same Singapore guide, read at source, for the filtration chain, the drum filter's self-clean, the media sizing and the bakki shower's function. 4 Evolution Aqua's own Nexus specification via a UK retailer's product page, read at source, for the capacity and recommended flow. 5 Japan's Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries, 2025 export results by commodity, **downloaded as the ministry's own PDF and text-extracted**, for the total, the tonnage, the growth rate and every destination's value, volume and change. **The ministry itself warns that figures to 2018 covered ornamental fish excluding goldfish and cannot be compared cleanly with 2019 onward.** 6 Two 2018 news reports, read at source, for the fish and both Waddington quotations. **They conflict on the buyer's nationality and neither gives a date or venue; the yen figure appears in only one. Claims that the fish later died are repeated by aggregators and verified nowhere.**

THE DEEP END · THE AUCTION SEASON

Dainichi opens the season's first on-site auction in Niigata on 25 October

About fifty lots of selected two-year-olds, and a web sale of a hundred more from its Aichi store. Only Promotion Association members may bid.

The calendar is the hobby's spine, and it turns this week. In **October and November** the koi come out of the mud and terraced ponds of Niigata into greenhouse pools, where they stay until April while buyers travel through the winter. **Dainichi**, of Ojiya, has posted its **99th live auction** for **25 and 26 October — "the first on-site auction of this season"**, about fifty lots of selected two-year-olds — and its **45th web auction** from the Toyota store in Aichi, closing on the 27th and 28th.[1]

You cannot bid. **"Only members of the All Japan Nishikigoi Promotion Association may participate,"** and Dainichi deals with the trade alone: a hobbyist reaches these fish through a dealer or not at all. The other great body, **ZNA** of Beppu, runs the opposite logic, barring producers and distributors from entering its show. Two institutions, two opposite membership rules, and the faction line runs between them.[1][2]

The Anglophone institutions of this hobby are visibly decaying while Japan's trade machinery runs its ninety-ninth auction.

That decay is not a mood, it is a set of HTTP responses. The **Associated Koi Clubs of America's** domain now redirects to a registrar's for-sale page; **KOI USA** magazine's serves a hosting placeholder; **Koi Magazine** in Britain redirects to a domain auction; the **British Koi Keepers Society**'s will not serve over TLS. Koiphen, Pond Boss and Koi-Bito all refused this desk, as did Reddit for a fifth consecutive issue. Meanwhile ZNA runs **live-judging seminars** at which participants rank five real fish against published reference rankings — bowl judging as an examinable discipline, in Japanese, while the English-speaking world's clubhouse is for sale.[2][3]

THE FILTRATION LADDER · UK RETAIL, READ AT SOURCE

TIER	ITEM	PRICE
Mid	Evolution Aqua Nexus 220+	£1,445
Shower	Burtons 3-tier stainless bakki	£1,295
High	Burtons BD-300 drum filter	£2,950
Over the top	Burtons TF-1000 through-flow	£4,575
Absurd	ProfiDrum Eco 75/80, US dealer	US$11,999.99

The air pump is **not included** with a bare Nexus and the filter does not work properly without one. Burtons publishes **no flow ratings and no lead times**, and media is extra at £95 per 16kg.[4]

THE CHATTER · JAPANESE AGAINST DOMESTIC

Both sides on the record. For domestic, **Ellen Kloubec** of an Iowa farm: **"Domestic koi often match or surpass the quality of imported koi"**. She owns a domestic farm, and her piece never mentions culling. For Europe, **Ronny Thorhauer** of JBL: breeders there **"can now match the Japanese not only in quality but also in price"**. Both are interested parties. **Neutral evidence exists on neither side.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE PUMP NOBODY CAN COMPARE

Evolution Aqua's Varipump is the energy centrepiece of the British koi market, and **its own page makes no running-cost claim at all** — no efficiency rating, no kilowatt-hours. Worse, the maker says the 10000 draws **90 watts** and its retailer's spec panel says **75**: a twenty-per-cent disagreement about the only number the product is sold on. The obvious comparator, Pondxpert's Variflow, **publishes no wattage or flow for any model**. The community argues about pump efficiency using figures half the market declines to print.[6]

SOURCES 1 Dainichi Koi Farm's own auction and how-to-purchase pages, **read at source in Japanese**, for both auction numbers, the dates and times, the lot counts, the two-year-old selection, the quoted season line and the trade-only and membership restrictions. **The farm's own page gives the Niigata event as 25–26 October in one place and heads the Aichi web sale 27–28 October while opening bidding on the 25th; the dates are internally inconsistent and are printed here as the range 25 to 28 October.** 2 ZNA's own Japanese and English sites, read at source, for its seat in Beppu, its entry restriction and its live-judging seminars and their published reference rankings. **ZNA publishes no chapter count, membership figure or founding year on any page this desk could read.** 3 Each failure in the paragraph above was observed directly by this desk on 19 October 2026: a registrar's for-sale page, a hosting placeholder, a domain-bidding redirect and a TLS name mismatch respectively, with Koiphen, Pond Boss, Koi-Bito and Reddit all returning 403. 4 A UK retailer's Nexus pages and a UK maker's own drum-filter, shower and media pages, read at source; a US dealer's page for the ProfiDrum. **No maker published a lead time anywhere this desk could read.** 5 A pond trade magazine's February 2024 article and a German aquatics firm's 2016 blog post, both read at source and both by named, interested authors. 6 Evolution Aqua's own Varipump specification page and the retailer's product page, read at source, for the two conflicting wattages and the absence of any running-cost claim; the competitor's own listing page for the missing specifications.

THE DEEP END · AZUKARI

Genki Koi lists a Dainichi-boarded Showa at $26,000 that never leaves Japan

Eight of the dealer's thirteen azukari fish are already sold as the Niigata harvest opens. The boarding fee is bundled into the price and never itemised.

The strangest product in the hobby is a fish you buy and do not receive. **Azukari**, in the dealer's own words, is a koi **"purchased by a customer but remain[ing] in Japan under the breeder's care"** — given more time in the mud ponds **"where it was originally raised"**, and collected a season later, larger. One Californian dealer's list runs from a two-year Tancho Kujaku at **$3,000** to a three-year Showa boarding in **Dainichi's own mud pond at $26,000**. Thirteen fish; **eight already sold**, in the week the harvest starts.[1]

What nobody publishes is the price of the boarding. It is folded into the purchase, and no dealer this desk could read quotes a per-season holding rate. **That it is unpublishable is the story.** The same opacity governs the fish: a **tategoi** is an unfinished young koi bought on projected potential, and as Thorhauer puts it from inside the trade, **"The breeder has a trained eye and, unlike the customer, is able to see a koi's potential in the growth stage"**. You pay most for the fish about which you know least, to the one person who knows. **No source quantifies how often a tategoi fails.**[2]

> ***A trade in which the counterparty has strictly better information and also sets the price.***

Underneath the grail tier the ladder is legible. A UK shop floor runs **£299** for a 38cm Chagoi to **£2,499** for a 73cm Yamabuki Ogon; an imported Momotaro at 44 to 56cm is **$530 to $750** — and the terms are the education: **"all sales on Japanese Koi are final and non-refundable"**. A serious keeper's real entry is a dealer *tosai*, fifty-three of which span **$800 to $2,500**. The named houses are few: **Sakai** of Hiroshima, who bred S Legend; **Dainichi**, which bred the Grand Champion at both the 55th and 56th All Japan shows; **Omosako** for Shiro Utsuri, **Isa** for Showa, **Torazo** who founded the Sanke bloodline.[3]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE IS A HUB, NOT A NURSERY

An academic survey puts it plainly: **"Most Singaporean farmers act as dealers. They import Japanese koi, rear them to marketable size, and sell or export them"** — they do not breed, because the licences are separate and costly. The names are **Nippon, Max, Zion, Diamond and Marugen**, not the obvious one: **the words koi and nishikigoi appear nowhere on Qian Hu's corporate site.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · MICRONS, NOT FISH

Price the treadmill and it resolves into one unit. Nexus 220+ £1,445, a Burtons drum £2,950, a through-flow £4,575, a ProfiDrum **$11,999.99**. Each rung buys mechanical fineness — seventy microns, sixty, **"down to one micron"**. **None of it buys a better fish.** And a koi here never gets the winter rest that structures the Japanese growth year: this island is a great ornamental-fish trading hub and a mediocre place to grow a champion.[4][5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Sheepdog trialling — a century of bloodline politics and five-figure dogs at Skipton.

Steel bicycle framebuilding — lugs against fillets, and builders who run a lottery for a slot.

Amateur mycology — spore prints, home cultivation, and hobbyists sequencing their own finds.

SOURCES 1 A California dealer's azukari collection page, read at source on 19 October 2026, for the definition quoted verbatim, every fish, breeder, age and price above, the bundled boarding fee and the sold-out count. 2 A German aquatics firm's tategoi article, read at source, for both quotations and the information asymmetry. **No source read anywhere in this research quantifies the tategoi failure rate, and this desk will not estimate one.** 3 A Surrey dealer's featured stock and a New Jersey dealer's Momotaro shipment and terms, read at source; a Hawaii dealer's tosai listings for the fifty-three fish and its breeder profiles for every house named; Dainichi's own championship page for the 55th and 56th Grand Champions. **Two breeders this desk was asked to check — one spelled Shintaro, one Oofuchi — appear in no dealer index it could read, and are therefore not named above.** 4 An academic survey of Singapore's koi aquaculture published by an agricultural policy platform in 2023, read at source, for the dealer-not-breeder structure, the farm names, the colour-and-growth finding, the decline since 2018 and the Lim Chu Kang re-designation; Qian Hu's own corporate site, read at source, for the absence of any koi business line. **The chiller running cost is from a Singapore aquascaping firm's own guide — a commercial source, flagged. Live Singapore dealer prices are held: one farm's site serves PHP errors and no prices, and every other local koi domain tried did not resolve.** 5 UK retailer and maker pages for the filtration prices, and a manufacturer's own claim for the one-micron figure, all read at source.

FITNESS · COGNITIVE LIFE EXPECTANCY

Alzheimer's & Dementia finds 7.2 years of cognitive health between the extremes

54,217 people across China, the United States, England and Korea. Training hard and staying social are not substitutes for each other: the hazard ratio between them is 1.01.

A study published in *Alzheimer's & Dementia* this month pooled four long-running ageing cohorts — **CHARLS in China, the Health and Retirement Study in the United States, ELSA in England and KLoSA in Korea** — and built multistate life tables for **54,217 people** aged fifty and over. It asks a question most exercise research does not: not whether you live longer, but how many of those years you spend without cognitive impairment, measured from age fifty.[1]

The answer is a ladder. Low structured exercise and low cognitive-social engagement buys **17.5 years** of cognitive impairment-free life from fifty. High exercise with low engagement: **23.2**. Low exercise with high engagement: **20.1**. Both high: **24.7**. The spread between the corners is **7.2 years**. For incident impairment the pooled hazard ratios run **0.80** (CI 0.73–0.88) for exercise alone against neither, **0.79** (CI 0.66–0.95) for engagement alone, and **0.70** (CI 0.61–0.81) for both.[1]

The gym does not buy you out of needing company, and company does not buy you out of needing the gym.

The result the optimisation crowd will misread is the one between the two middle rungs. High exercise against high engagement gives a hazard ratio of **1.01**, confidence interval 0.89 to 1.16 — statistically indistinguishable. They are **not interchangeable, and they are not substitutes**: doing one at full tilt lands you in the same place as doing the other, and only doing both moves you further. For a reader with two wearables and a trainer, the uncomfortable half of this result is the half no device measures. **Note what the paper does not give: there are no confidence intervals on the life-expectancy figures themselves, only on the hazard ratios, so the 7.2 years carries no interval and none is invented here.**[1]

7.2 years

COGNITIVE IMPAIRMENT-FREE LIFE EXPECTANCY FROM AGE 50, BEST CORNER AGAINST WORST[1]

THE CHATTER · DOES STACKING ACTUALLY ADD UP?

A Bayesian network meta-analysis in *Advances in Nutrition*, online **17 October**, ran **78 trials and 8,452 participants** at exactly the question the longevity forums argue about: do diet and exercise interventions add. All four structured-exercise nodes lowered blood pressure; resistance training alone lowered fasting glucose. But the component analysis found additivity held only for **waist circumference and triglycerides** — for the other four outcomes the combined effect was not the sum of its parts. Sometimes stacking adds. Usually it does not.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE AUTHORS, AGAINST THEMSELVES

No external methodologist has gone on the record against either paper, so the sharpest criticism available is the authors' own, and it is unusually frank. Exposure was **"self-reported and harmonized from cohort-specific items"** with residual measurement error **"likely"**; **"cognitive impairment definitions differed across cohorts"**; income and wealth **"could not be consistently harmonized"**; no fitness or brain structure was measured anywhere; and decisively, **"the observational design precludes causal inference"**, with the life-expectancy gaps to be read as **"model-based associations"**. The nutrition paper is equally honest: certainty was **"low to very low for most comparisons"**, and it declines to name a winning intervention at all.[1][2]

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

Both papers are associations, not prescriptions, and both sets of authors say so. **Held:** no named longevity-discourse figure has commented on either at the time of going to press, and this desk will not manufacture a generic reaction in place of one.

SOURCES 1 *Alzheimer's & Dementia*, October 2026, **full text read at source**, for the four cohorts and their individual sample sizes, the pooled total, the baseline age and mean, the multistate method, all four life-expectancy figures, every hazard ratio with its confidence interval including the 1.01 between the two single-exposure groups, and every limitation quoted above. **The paper publishes no confidence intervals on the life-expectancy estimates; the intervals given here all attach to hazard ratios.** 2 *Advances in Nutrition*, online ahead of print 17 October 2026, read as the indexed abstract, for the trial and participant counts, the Bayesian and component methods, the per-outcome findings, the additivity result and both quoted statements about certainty. **Neither the step-count floor of No. 135 nor the aquatic-exercise meta-analysis of No. 136 is re-run here.**

THE DIARY · BOOKING THIS WEEK

Kenshi Yonezu's Singapore tickets go on general sale at noon on Thursday

SIX60's presales open today and tomorrow, with general sale on Wednesday. The Kyushu Basho is already sold out on all fifteen days.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

26 OCT — **Des Bishop Live in Singapore**
VICTORIA THEATRE · GENERAL SALE OPEN · **18+**; NO PRICE ON THE PROMOTER PAGE

3 NOV — **yung kai · Stay With The Ocean Asia Tour**
CAPITOL THEATRE, 8PM · ON SALE · VIP PACKAGES LISTED WITHOUT PRICES

13–22 Nov — ★ **Singapore Writers Festival 2026**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · **FESTIVAL PASS S$30, YOUTH PASS S$15** · 100+ PASS PROGRAMMES

14 NOV — **LUCY · 9th Concert 'Island' Encore**
CAPITOL THEATRE, 6PM · S$138 TO S$218 ACROSS FIVE TIERS, EXCL. BOOKING FEE

20–29 Nov — **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · MANY PROGRAMMES **FREE**; TICKETED FROM S$29 · FAMILY STRANDS 21–22 NOV

28 & 29 Nov — **BABYMONSTER · World Tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 6PM · S$168 TO S$358 · **NEITHER NIGHT MARKED SOLD OUT**

10 DEC — **SIX60 · Right Here Right Now**
*SCAPE GROUND THEATRE, 8PM · **PRESALE TODAY 10AM AND TOMORROW NOON; GENERAL WED 21 OCT NOON**

29 JAN — ★ **Kenshi Yonezu · Ghost World Tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 8PM · **GENERAL SALE THU 22 OCT NOON, WAITING ROOM 11.30AM** · ONE NIGHT

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

24 Oct–1 Nov — **SMBC Nippon Series 2026**
FOUR POSSIBLE STADIUMS · DATES FIXED, **TEAMS AND VENUE ORDER NOT YET DECIDED** — BOOKING FLIGHTS ON THIS IS A BET ON THE CLIMAX SERIES

26 Oct–4 Nov — **Tokyo International Film Festival**
HIBIYA, YURAKUCHO, MARUNOUCHI AND GINZA · **GENERAL SALES OPENED 17 OCT**, STAGGERED BY SECTION · PRICES ON A PAGE THIS DESK COULD NOT REACH

30 Oct–8 Nov — **DESIGNART TOKYO 2026**
SEVEN AREAS ACROSS TOKYO · ADMISSION NOT STATED ON THE ENGLISH INDEX

8–22 Nov — **Kyushu Basho · November Grand Sumo**
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · CHAIR SEATS WERE ¥2,000 TO ¥6,000 · **THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN SITE SAYS SOLD OUT, ALL FIFTEEN DAYS**

14 Nov–28 Mar — ★ **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM, UENO · ¥2,400, ADVANCE ¥2,200 · **FREE TO UNDER-18S** · CLOSED MONDAYS AND AN IRREGULAR WINTER CALENDAR

19 Nov–11 Jan — **Ways of Reading · and the museum's centenary archives**
TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM · **BOTH FREE** · UPSTAIRS FROM THE ORSAY SHOW, WHICH MAKES IT A HALF-DAY

PLANNING NOTES · AND WHAT THIS DESK DROPPED

Two on-sales fall inside this issue's shelf life: **SIX60** today, tomorrow and Wednesday, and **Kenshi Yonezu on Thursday at noon**, which is the only item on the page that needs a reader at a keyboard at a specific hour. For a twelve-year-old the economics are kind again — **free under 18** at the Orsay show, two free exhibitions upstairs, a **S$15** Youth Pass at the Writers Festival, and several free Kalaa Utsavam strands. **Des Bishop is 18+**; keep it away from the family column. The Kyushu sumo is the useful corrective: still on, listed by aggregators, and gone at face value on every single day. **Dropped for want of a primary source:** the Melbourne Cup Carnival, whose two official sites returned 503 and whose own index publishes no 2026 dates or prices; the Standard Chartered Singapore Marathon, whose site still carries only the 2025 edition; the Tokyo International Art Fair, aggregator-only; and **Guns N' Roses**, which appears on a Singapore venue's site solely inside a "popular searches" box with no date, venue or on-sale status. **Post Malone remains barred.**[1]

SOURCES 1 Every event above was confirmed on a primary page — the promoter's, the venue's, the festival's or the museum's own site — and read there on 18 and 19 October 2026: a concert promoter's own Singapore event pages for Des Bishop, yung kai, LUCY, BABYMONSTER, SIX60 and Kenshi Yonezu, including every published price tier, every presale and general-sale time and the 18+ restriction; the Singapore Writers Festival's own site for its dates, venues and both pass prices; Esplanade's own Kalaa Utsavam page for the dates, the free programmes and the ticketed floor; Nippon Professional Baseball's own English site for the Japan Series dates and the undetermined teams; the film festival's own site and ticket page for the dates and the 17 October staggered on-sale; DESIGNART's own English index; the ticketing agent's sumo page for the seat prices and **the Japan Sumo Association's own English site for the sold-out notice**; and the Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum's own exhibition pages for both shows, all prices, the under-18 admission and the closure calendar. **Aggregator listings were treated as leads only, and everything that could not be confirmed on a primary source was dropped rather than printed, and is named above.**

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW ROOMS

Shan Li You opens a Yunnan mountain-cooking counter in Jewel Changi Airport

Curry Popo at Alexandra Village is the only one of the four a critic has eaten at and reviewed. Two of the others have no independent review in existence.

Shan Li You has opened at Jewel, the first room in Singapore built on Yunnan mountain cooking rather than the Sichuan or Cantonese defaults — the venue's own words are a brand **"rooted in Yunnan's mountain ingredients and ethnic culture"**, with seasonal wild mushrooms, edible flowers and rice noodles. The signatures flagged are porcini, truffle and egg rice; a wild-pepper and sour-fruit beef soup. A pot of tea you brew yourself runs **S$1.90++** a head. It is **not halal-certified**, and the two sources disagree on its opening hours.[1]

And that is all this desk will say about it, because **no one has reviewed it**. The only write-up is a first look whose author states plainly that they have yet to get hold of the menu and the prices. **The signature dishes have no published price.** Too new to call, and the honest version of a restaurant column says so instead of lifting the adjectives out of a launch post.

Curry Popo is the opposite case and the best thing on this page: one man, one stall at **Alexandra Village Food Centre**, open since early August, selling essentially one dish from his grandmother's recipe. **S$8.80** for the drumstick-and-thigh combo, S$5 for curry vegetables. A critic who ate there on **18 October** calls the curry **"lemak but rempah-heavy, and drinkable rather than thick"** and the stall **"well worth a trip"** — then files the dissent himself: he wants it **"a notch less spicy, for the sake of my stomach"**, the heat **"slowly builds with each spoonful"**, and the menu is thin. No score given. One man cooking and taking orders is the whole constraint, so go at eleven or after two.[2]

Calendar Coffee, on South Bridge Road from the June Coffee team, is a desserts-and-drinks room with no mains and a **French toast series** that is the reason to go — apple pie **S$11++**, blueberry cheesecake S$12++, smoked salmon and cream cheese S$14++. The single review calls the toast series its most distinctive offering and warns it gets crowded; a search for any second write-up **returned nothing at all**. Tuesday to Sunday, eleven to six, which compresses the queue into six hours.[3]

The fourth is a date rather than a verdict. **Torimitsu** takes a three-month residency inside **Tanuki Raw** at Orchard Central from **Tuesday 28 October**: an eight-skewer yakitori omakase over binchotan followed by chicken ramen, **fifteen seats a session**, from chef-owner **Takuhei Yamada**, who trained under Yoshiteru Ikegawa at Torishiki in Tokyo. **No price is published.** Fifteen covers a sitting across twelve weeks is the scarcest supply in town; book the hour the page opens.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE ROUNDUPS SAY

Two of October's big local roundups were, from this desk's point of view, almost entirely unusable: between them they name fourteen venues this book has already run to the end of its own rotation rule. That is a useful signal about the churn — the same openings circulate through the same lists for months — and it is why this page skews to the last fortnight's individual write-ups rather than the monthly ten-bests.

THE SCEPTIC · THREE LAUNCHES AND ONE MEAL

Of the four rooms above, **one has been eaten at and judged by a named critic**. One has a single favourable first look and no second opinion anywhere. One has a first look whose author says they could not get the prices. One has not opened. A column that let launch copy stand in for a verdict would read identically to this page and tell the reader nothing — so the distinction is printed rather than smoothed. **Reddit, normally the corrective here, has refused this desk for a fifth consecutive issue, which removes the local food subreddits from the evidence entirely.**

SOURCES 1 The mall's own directory listing and a Singapore food site's first look of 15 October 2026, both read at source, for the concept and its quoted description, the signature dishes, the tea service and price, the address and the halal status. **The two give different opening hours and neither publishes a price for any signature dish; both gaps are printed rather than resolved.** 2 A Singapore critic's review of 18 October 2026, read at source, for the opening month, the stall location and hours, both prices, every quoted judgement and every stated criticism. **Halal status is not stated by the source and is not asserted here.** 3 A Singapore food site's review of 15 October 2026, read at source, for the parentage, the format, all four French-toast prices, the drinks, the address and hours, the quoted verdict and the crowding warning. **A targeted search for any second write-up of this café returned nothing, so no consensus is claimed.** 4 A Singapore listings magazine's preview of 25 September 2026, read at source, for the residency dates, the format, the seat count, the chef and his training. **It is a listing, not a meal; no price is published and the room has not opened. Every venue on this page was checked against this book's own table ledger before selection; the two carried over from No. 126 are run here on a new, dated peg.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · HUNDI

Bangladesh Bank logged record remittances of $35.6bn; the kerb market explains the surge

Monthly inflows have fallen below $3bn and the kerb dollar trades at Tk128 against a bank rate of Tk122.30. The record is already unwinding.

The word is older than the banks. হুন্ডি — *hundi*, from the Sanskrit *hundikā*, the bill of exchange that financed the Bengal trade centuries before anyone opened a branch. Today it means the informal system that moves money across borders without moving it: a worker in Riyadh hands cash to an agent, the agent's partner in Sylhet pays the family in taka, and nothing crosses a frontier except a message. South Asia's hawala — and the reason Bangladesh's most celebrated statistic does not mean what the headlines say.[1]

Start with the number, read off the central bank's own monthly table. In the financial year to June 2026, wage earners sent home **$35,589 million** through formal channels against **$30,329 million** the year before: growth of **17.3 per cent**, on top of a year that had grown by a quarter. March 2026 was the largest month in the country's history at **$3,752 million**. Gross reserves reached **$36.31 billion**. Dhaka's press ran "record" on the first of almost every month.[2]

Nobody started working harder. The money simply changed lane — and the lane it left was the one the elite used.

Here is what that growth is measuring. Hundi is a **two-sided market**: the migrant supplies dollars abroad, and somebody inside Bangladesh has to want dollars outside it or the agent cannot square his book. That second side has a name — importers under-invoicing, and above all the politically connected moving capital out. When the Hasina government fell in **August 2024** the demand side collapsed. The kerb premium vanished. Migrant flows did not grow. **They merely became visible.**

Which makes the series stranger than a measure of diaspora generosity. It is a **negative image of capital flight**: a monthly reading of how much of what migrants send is permitted to be seen, and therefore of how little is being taken out the other way. Bangladesh's balance of payments improved by roughly five billion dollars a year not because the country earned more, but because for two years fewer people were stealing. That is the most precise price anyone has put on a Bangladeshi change of government, published in a spreadsheet without a word of commentary.

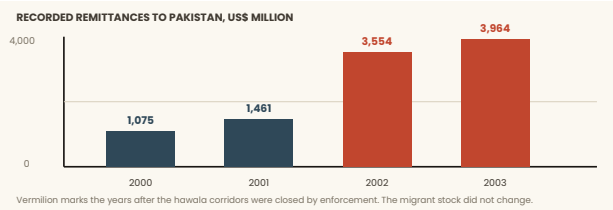
There is a cruder reason the number flatters. Since 2019 the state has paid a cash incentive on every formal transfer, lifted to **2.5 per cent** in 2022, with transfers up to **Tk5 lakh** undocumented. **Zakaria Swapan**, who founded a Bangladeshi payments company and so has no academic reputation to protect, costed it in April at about **Tk7,000 crore a year — some US$580 million** — and argued it should be retired over four quarters. His case is that part of the record is an artefact: service-export and freelancing income misbooked as remittance, and foreign currency round-tripped to harvest the subsidy. His supporting witness is the central bank's own former governor, **Ahsan H Mansur**, who said in August 2024 that **"Dubai-based companies are exploiting the stimulus."** India takes **$129 billion** a year with no cash incentive at all.[3]

+17.3%

FORMAL REMITTANCE GROWTH IN THE YEAR TO JUNE 2026, ON THE CENTRAL BANK'S OWN MONTHLY SERIES[2]

SOURCES 1 The etymology and the mechanics of the system are long-established and uncontested in the South Asian literature; this desk states them as background, not as a finding. 2 **Bangladesh Bank's own "Wage Earners' Remittance" monthly table, read at source at bb.org.bd** — for every monthly figure, the March 2026 record and the two financial-year totals. **The annual sums are this desk's own addition of the bank's published monthly series, not a figure the bank prints.** The reserve levels, the near-final financial-year total and the single-day record are from a Dhaka financial daily of 29 June 2026, read at source. **The one external authority this essay wanted — a reported remark by the World Bank's remittances lead that up to half the growth may be a channel shift — appears in a Dhaka paper of 17 October this desk could not open at any URL tried. It is therefore neither quoted nor relied on; the argument rests on the central bank's series and the money changers' published rates.** 3 A Dhaka business daily's opinion piece of 25 April 2026 by the named founder, read at source, for the incentive's history and rates, the Tk5 lakh documentation threshold, the Tk7,000 crore annual cost, the Indian comparison and the quoted remark by the former governor, which that piece attributes to August 2024.

The precedent is exact, and it is Pakistani. After **11 September 2001**, global enforcement shut the hawala corridors almost overnight. Recorded remittances to Pakistan went from **$1,075 million in 2000** to **$1,461 million in 2001**, then to **$3,554 million in 2002** and **$3,964 million in 2003**. That is a two-and-a-half-fold jump in a single year, in a country whose migrant population had not changed. Nobody started working harder. The money changed lane, because the other lane had been closed for it. And the sequel supplies the warning: Pakistan's formal share drifted back toward the kerb every time the premium reopened.[1]



Meridian original, plotted from the World Bank's personal-remittances series for Pakistan, downloaded from the bank's own data interface.[1]

If the thesis is right, it carries an uncomfortable corollary. The external stabilisation that Bangladesh has spent two years celebrating — reserves back above thirty-six billion, the IMF programme eased, talk of graduating out of least-developed status resumed — rests on a **political** variable, not an economic one. It is not that the country became more productive. It is that a particular group of people stopped exporting money. Which means the hundi spread is not a curiosity of the kerb market. It is a live, high-frequency, publicly observable instrument for measuring whether a new elite has formed and started doing what the last one did.

Dhaka has been circling this without quite saying it. The city's papers run the record as a triumph on the first of the month and interrogate it everywhere else: one asked in February why the taka remains weak if the dollars are really arriving, which is the embarrassing question in its shortest form. A regional policy journal ran a piece in June on how little of the boom reaches households. And the trade's own argument — whether hundi can be reined in at all while mobile wallets make settlement trivial — has been running in the business press for two years. What nobody has done is cross-plot the central bank's monthly table against the money changers' kerb rate, which takes about ten minutes and answers the question.[3]

It is worth being precise about why a two-sided market behaves this way. The migrant is the supply side and he is almost perfectly inelastic: he sends what he can, every month, whatever the channel costs, because the money is not an investment but an obligation. The demand side is the opposite — discretionary, concentrated, and politically exposed. So the volume through the formal system is set almost entirely by how badly somebody inside the country wants dollars outside it. When that want collapses, the agent cannot clear his book, his rate worsens, and the migrant walks into a bank. Nothing about the migrant changed. The arithmetic of the other side of the trade did.

$35.6bn

FORMAL REMITTANCES TO BANGLADESH IN THE YEAR TO JUNE 2026, AGAINST $30.3BN THE YEAR BEFORE[4]

The spread is a dial that reads how much is being taken out. In August it started moving the wrong way.

On **24 August 2026** the Money Changers Association of Bangladesh capped the cash dollar at **Tk126.50 selling and Tk125.50 buying**, after the kerb rate reached **Tk128**. Banks that day were buying expatriate remittances at **Tk122.30** and settling letters of credit at up to Tk122.95. That gap — roughly **four and a half per cent** — is hundi's entire margin, and it had been close to nothing. The association's president denied manipulation, arguing the sector **"lacks the scale and capital to influence the market"**, and blamed fewer expatriates carrying cash and a rush for dollars after India reopened medical and travel visas for Bangladeshis.[2]

SOURCES 1 The World Bank's personal-remittances-received series for Pakistan, in current US dollars, **requested directly from the bank's own data interface and read as returned** — for all four annual figures and the figure above. The characterisation of post-2001 enforcement closing hawala corridors is the standard account in the literature and is given as background. 2 A Dhaka business daily of 24 August 2026, read at source, for the money changers' capped rates, the Tk128 kerb level, the bank remittance and letter-of-credit rates, the association president's quoted denial and the two reasons he gave. **The four-and-a-half-per-cent premium is this desk's own arithmetic on those published rates.** 4 Bangladesh Bank's own monthly table, as cited on p21; the annual totals are this desk's addition of its published months. 3 The Dhaka and regional coverage characterised here was identified by headline, outlet and date in a news index; **the article bodies could not be opened from here — the Daily Star's own search and tag pages are stale and the regional journal returned 403 — so they are described as existing and not quoted.** The one piece of that commentary this desk did read at source is the April opinion column cited on p21.

The rest of the dial agrees. Monthly inflows fell **below $3 billion for a second consecutive month** in the summer. First-quarter growth for the new financial year came in at **13.3 per cent**, against the **17.6** the year had closed on. The government has begun reaching for the instruments a state reaches for when a channel is reopening: an "Expatriates Card" to pull transfers into formal rails, and a proposal to give Rohingya refugees limited banking access specifically to reduce hundi risk. These are the moves of an administration that can see the spread too.[1]

A fair sceptic has two strong objections and both should be conceded. The first is that none of this requires politics at all: the crawling peg of May 2024 and the subsequent move toward a market rate simply closed the official-to-kerb gap, and hundi always shrinks when that gap shrinks. The second is Swapan's — that part of the record is not real, being service-export income misbooked and currency round-tripped to collect a subsidy that waves through undocumented transfers up to Tk5 lakh. Both are right.

An incentive that can be gamed is proof the state cannot tell a real remittance from a laundered one. That is not a footnote to the argument. It is the argument.

But notice what conceding them does. If the exchange-rate unification is the mechanism, the question becomes why it was politically survivable in 2025 and not in 2023 — and the answer is that the constituency which profited from the gap had just lost its protection. And if a measurable slice of the record is laundered or misbooked, then the state's own flagship number cannot distinguish a migrant's wages from a round-trip. A country whose external position depends on a statistic it cannot audit has not stabilised. It has been lucky, and it has written the luck down as income.

Which is the part worth carrying out of this issue. A number is not a measurement of the thing it is named after; it is a measurement of what the measuring apparatus is able to see. Bangladesh's remittance series is an honest count of honest transfers, published monthly by a competent central bank, and it still tells you more about the people who left the country in August 2024 than about the people sending money home. The series did not lie. It was simply answering a different question from the one everyone was asking it — and it has already begun to answer it the other way.

There is a wider lesson here for anyone reading an emerging-market statistic from a desk in Singapore. The numbers that get quoted are the ones a state can produce cheaply and publish monthly, and those are almost always flow numbers passing through regulated institutions. What they cannot see is the parallel system — which, in most of the countries that matter, is where a large share of the money actually moves. So a reform that merely pushes activity from the invisible system into the visible one shows up as growth, and a political shock that empties the invisible system shows up as a boom. Neither is production. Both are reclassification, and the second is reversible in a quarter.

13.3%

FIRST-QUARTER REMITTANCE GROWTH FOR THE NEW FINANCIAL YEAR, AGAINST 17.6 THE YEAR BEFORE[1]

Tk128

KERB DOLLAR IN AUGUST AGAINST A BANK REMITTANCE RATE OF TK122.30 — HUNDI'S MARGIN, REOPENING[2]

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY THIS

Three things, each checkable. **One:** the kerb premium closes back below one per cent while monthly inflows hold above $3bn — which would say the 2024–26 shift was exchange-rate mechanics, not politics. **Two:** Bangladesh Bank or the IMF publishes a decomposition showing the growth is genuinely new migrant income rather than channel shift. **Three:** remittances keep rising through 2027 *while* the premium widens, which would break the relationship this essay rests on entirely. This desk has logged all three with dates.

SOURCES 1 The sub-$3bn months, the 13.3 per cent first-quarter figure, the Expatriates Card and the Rohingya banking proposal were each identified by headline, outlet and date in a news index across August, September and October 2026. **Their article bodies could not be opened from here, so they are reported as published items rather than quoted, and none of the argument above depends on a figure that appears only in them: the growth deceleration is also visible in the central bank's own monthly series on p21.** 2 The money changers' published rates of 24 August 2026, read at source and cited in full on p22. **A note on the Undercurrent's own test.** This desk ran the negative check before writing: three separate index queries for this subject across eight major Western outlets returned nothing on it. The nearest adjacent work is a Financial Times film of September 2025 on Bangladeshi capital flight — the mirror of this argument rather than this argument, since it does not treat the remittance record, the kerb premium or the 2026 reversal. **It is named here because a reader deserves to know the ground is not entirely empty.**

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

Pencilled in

Iran's foreign minister offered on Saturday to reopen the Strait of Hormuz in seven days — the sixth for the shipping, the seventh for the talks — if Washington complies. No American official has answered (p3). On Friday the President waived every Russian provision of a sanctions law a day before it was due to bite, leaving the Act on the books to expire in 2031. Today Albertans vote on ten questions, the tenth asking whether their government should begin a legal process toward a future binding referendum. None of the ten binds anyone (p4).

It is a book of dates that do not hold. Singapore named seven Indonesian companies under a law allowing a hundred thousand dollars a day and set them no deadline; three had the same notice in 2015 (p5). Beijing published its AI export rules as a draft open until 15 November, in which the exemption for open weights is a licence it can revoke (p7). Apple took money on Friday night for a phone that arrives in late January (p9). And at twenty-one minutes to four tomorrow morning a Japanese rocket leaves Tanegashima to bring back ten grams of a Martian moon in 2031.

Which leaves the quiet one. Bangladesh has spent two years booking a remittance record as earned income; the honest reading is that it measured how few people were taking money out — already reversing on the kerb (p21). Against all of it, one object on this cover keeps its appointment: a spring one point eight metres long, coiled into a steel case, that runs for exactly ten days and stops (p10). The difference between a promise and a specification is that somebody measured the second one.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a shipping-intelligence service's own transit series; the White House waiver through two American outlets whose accounts of its scope disagree and are printed as disagreeing; Elections Alberta's own pages and the Clarity Act at the Canadian justice department; **the Singapore government's own air-quality API, read directly at two endpoints after the environment agency's pages again rendered nothing machine-readable**; China's draft export list through two outlets and a reader who installed Chinese office software to read the original; Apple's Singapore store; Metacritic, Rotten Tomatoes and Box Office Mojo; ASSA ABLOY's own annual report, Sold Secure's live register and a Seattle Police Department bulletin; Japan's agriculture and transport ministries on nishikigoi; and **Bangladesh Bank's own monthly remittance table and the World Bank's Pakistan series, both downloaded and read line by line. Where a source refused this desk — Reddit for a fifth consecutive issue, and this week also both Singapore broadsheets, Reuters, PUB, the anti-corruption bureau, Metacritic's album pages, Koiphen and several others — the page says so and prints what could be read instead. Two corrections run on p4 and p11. Nothing here was invented.**